Green in cultures and traditions

In different cultures green has **surprisingly different meanings**. **Paradise, envy, luck, renewal and poison**. **None of these meanings excludes the others.** Let us look attentively and gently at a few places.

This chapter therefore shows **two levels**. First, how green is read in different **cultures**, and then how **traditional systems** look at it, using it as an image.

Green in different cultures

Islam

In Islam green is often seen as **the colour of paradise**. The Quran describes the inhabitants of paradise in green garments (for example Surah 18, verse 31, and Surah 76, verse 21).

Green refers to **greenery, water and life**, rare in the desert. Many Islamic countries have green in their flags.

A colour that is ordinary for us can be somewhere **a symbol of the highest blessing**.

Ireland

Ireland is nicknamed **the Emerald Isle** and the shamrock is its symbol. On **St Patrick's** Day people dress in green.

The nickname refers to a lush landscape fed by rain. **Green later became linked** with Irish nationalism too and is one of the stripes of the Irish tricolour.

The colour of the land and the colour of **identity** can merge.

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China

Green jade is valued in China as **a symbol of virtue and protection**. At the same time the idiom “to wear a green hat” means that a husband is being cheated on, and so a green hat should not be given as a gift.

Jade is linked with beauty and permanence. The idiom comes from folk speech.

The same colour can be a **treasure** in one object and an embarrassment in another.

The USA and money

The first American paper money of 1861 had a green back and people began to call it “**greenbacks**”. When smaller banknotes were introduced in 1929, green stayed, among other things because of the availability and durability of the pigment and its link with **trust in the state currency**.

The very original reason for choosing green is not certain. Different currencies use different colours.

Ask what money reminds you of. **The calm** of paid rent, **the freedom** to choose work, or pressure and worries? That too can show in how you perceive green.

Green in traditional systems

Every tradition looks at green **a little differently**, but all take it seriously. It is an old symbolic language and an inspiration, not a healing guide.

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Traditional Chinese medicine

In the Chinese tradition there are five elements. Wood, fire, earth, metal and water. **Green belongs to wood.** With wood are grouped spring, wind, the sour taste, anger and frustration as emotions, and the liver and gallbladder as organs. **Wood is the element of growth**. **Flexible, reaching upward**, that **bends and does not break**. The Chinese word qing (青) also covers green and blue together.

The liver here is not just an organ. The tradition ascribes to it keeping the flow of energy and emotions smooth. **When the flow stalls**, it describes irritability, tension and a feeling that it "is not going on". When wood grows freely, we are flexible and can plan and also change direction.

How it relates to the colour green. Green is the colour of wood, that is of growth and movement. And at the same time it is the supply for red. **Wood feeds fire.** Green is therefore not the opposite of red, it is its fuel. When you want more courage and energy, start with green. With rest, movement in nature, a change of routine.

What you can take from it. Ask yourself whether your wood is growing freely or is stuck. When it is stuck, it tends to be irritability and a feeling that you cannot go on. Movement, stretching, nature, a change of routine and saying aloud what is pressing all help. When there is too little of it, you lose direction and the wish to start anything. A small concrete plan, spring and the first shoots help. A herb in a pot is enough.

Ask yourself

*"What in my life is getting stuck and what would help me today **bend, and not break**?"*

Wood. Why precisely green, spring and a tree?

Imagine a tree in spring. New green leaves appear, branches lengthen and everything starts growing again. In the Chinese view wood represents precisely growth and flexibility. A branch is firm, but can also bend. When it is too stiff, it breaks more easily. Green can remind you of **a beginning** that does not have to be big or perfect.

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Growing is not enough. You also need to say what is pressing

For the third time you agree to something you do not want to do. Outwardly you say “sure”, inwardly irritation grows. Perhaps you need rest, help or to say that you will not take on another task. Anger has various causes and from being angry you cannot determine the state of the liver. It is more useful to catch what you are angry about and what you need to change. You can try saying a concrete need aloud: “I have no strength for that today” or “I need us to share this.”

Traditional Chinese medicine uses wood as an image. It is not a diagnosis and does not replace a doctor. From the assignment to the liver it does not follow that a green picture cleanses the liver.

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Ayurveda

Ayurveda is an old Indian teaching about health. In it a person is described by three types of "energy", the so-called doshas. Vata (air, restlessness), pitta (fire, intensity) and kapha (earth and water, heaviness). Colours are chosen to balance what there is too much of. Opposites are treated with opposites. **Green is cooling, calm and soothing**.

How it relates to the colour green. In contemporary Ayurvedic readings green and blue tones are often recommended for balancing pitta. **Sources on colours in Ayurveda differ in detail**, so take it as a general direction, not as a rule.

Pitta

This is how a woman is described who is purposeful, quick and thorough, and flares up easily. **Green cools and calms her.** The tradition advises cooling colours, such as green, blue or white.

- **Add green**
  Plants in the flat*, a sage or mint wall, green clothing.*
- **Add some cool**
  White and blue, water, a walk by a river or in a forest.

Vata

This is how a woman is described who is imaginative and quick, but restless, who is often cold and sleeps worse. Some sources recommend green, mainly in warmer shades. **It is best to notice how you really feel in green.**

- **Warmer shades**
  Olive and moss *for a blanket, a jumper or cushions. Calm without coldness.*
- **Evening and sleep**
  Soft, muted shades and warm light.

Kapha

This is how a woman is described who is calm, steady and patient, but who easily becomes heavy. Some sources do not recommend green for kapha, because it would calm her even more. **Lively colours** suit her.

- **Green in moderation**
  Lighter spring shades *(lime, apple), not a dark forest green.*
- **Add liveliness**
  Red, orange or yellow. A jumper, scarf, tablecloth.

An online test will not reliably determine your dosha. If you are more interested, consult a qualified Ayurvedic practitioner. It is not treatment.

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A Jungian view

Carl Gustav Jung, a Swiss psychiatrist, understood colours as symbols that have **two layers**. **A personal one** (what we have experienced with a colour) and one common to all people (images that repeat across eras and cultures).

In his lectures at the ETH in Zurich (1938 to 1939) he assigned green to **sensation**. He was interested in how we perceive the world through the body and senses. We see, hear, touch, **we are here and now**. Red for him belonged to feeling, green to the senses.

How it relates to the colour green. Green can remind you. **Come back to the body** and to what you are really perceiving right now. What do I see, hear, feel on my skin. Not what I think I should feel.

What you can take from it. When you are in your head, overloaded and constantly planning, green in the form of observation helps. Look out of the window at the greenery, touch a leaf, stroke moss. When, on the contrary, you live only in perceiving and do not want to change anything, red (feeling) or yellow (an idea) may do you good.

Jung did not want colours to be made into a dictionary. **The same green can be calm for one woman and boredom for another**. **We always ask what it means for you.** Jung's ideas about colours are a symbolic framework, not verified science.

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Feng shui

Feng shui is the Chinese art of arranging a space so that it is good to live in. In it green is the colour of **wood**, the element of growth, **vitality and new beginnings**. Wood belongs to spring and to the directions east and southeast. In the map of the house called the bagua, east is linked with family and health and southeast with growth and abundance. Green is therefore usually the colour of **health and family harmony**.

According to the tradition wood needs balance. Water feeds it, fire exhausts it and metal chops it. That is why heavy metal decorations are not recommended in the green part of the house in feng shui.

Simple tips

- **Do you want more growth?**
  Start with one healthy plant in a place where you will see it every day.
- **Want more calm?**
  Choose sage, moss or olive. Leave rich green for small accents.
- **Is it already too much?**
  Add wood, linen, cream or more free space.
- **Green does not suit you?**
  Swap it for another colour. Your feeling is more important than the rules.

What people say and what holds true

MYTH The more plants, the more luck.

TRUTH According to the tradition a healthy and tended plant counts. Neglected and withered plants, on the contrary, drain energy. Fewer, but healthy ones are better.

MYTH Green brings money.

TRUTH The southeast is the zone of growth and abundance, but green alone ensures nothing. The whole matters.

MYTH Green is always calm.

TRUTH Rich, sour shades can also exhaust. **Calm** comes rather from soft, natural tones.

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Clothing

Green in clothing behaves similarly to green in a flat. Best as a colour that **calms** you and keeps you grounded. According to traditional advisers your personal element matters too. Wood helps one person, green does not suit another. In practice. Let your body and the mirror advise you.

What green works well with

- **Wood and linen**
  A natural, lived-in impression. Green does not have to shout in them.
- **Cream and white**
  A lighter and airier whole in which green breathes.
- **Brown and earth**
  More earthy and grounding. Green grows, brown holds.
- **Red**
  A strong counterpart. Watch the size of the areas so that it does not look Christmassy.
- **Blue**
  A cooler and calmer impression. Try which one will be the main one.
- **Grey and black**
  An elegant and deep impression. Use only a little black.

Before you repaint a whole room, try **a throw**, **a fabric** or a larger colour **sample**. Hold a large sample to the wall and look at it in the morning and in the evening in your own lighting. **A screen does not replace the shade**.

Feng shui has several schools and the recommendations differ. **Take them as inspiration** for how it feels to live in a space.

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Feng shui room by room

What works, what to watch for and a simple tip.

Living room

What works. Plants, green cushions or a curtain. They suit mainly the east and southeast part of a room. **Sage** and a muted olive may suit one wall or a larger textile, they are less conspicuous than bright greens and let the people and things around stand out.

What to watch for. In a dark room a lot of grey-green can feel dull. Forest green creates a cosy corner, but takes away a feeling of lightness. If the room is heavy and shaded, start with an armchair, a picture or a smaller area.

A simple tip. Linen, wool and wood make sage and olive **softer and more natural**. A glossy rich green gives a more artificial impression than a matt one.

Kitchen and dining room

What works. Herbs on the windowsill and green in textiles. Water is already there, so wood has something to drink. Olive with wood can feel earthy and cosy.

What to watch for. In a small north-facing room first compare a sample with a lighter variant. A cold green can emphasise a feeling of chill. On the worktop you need light in which you can tell food apart well, not a green tint.

A simple tip. Wood, ceramics and linen warm olive and sage. A cold green next to glossy metal adds chill.

Bedroom

What works. Soft and muted shades (sage, moss). Plants yes, but healthy and tended. **A muted green** behind the bed or in the bed linen, if it is pleasant for you.

What to watch for. A garish lime on a large area is too striking for evening rest. Green coloured lighting is not automatically suitable for sleeping. In the evening brightness and the time of lighting matter too.

A simple tip. Cotton and linen in a muted green are pleasant to look at and to touch. A cold gloss suits falling asleep less well. What do you see just before you fall asleep and how does it feel to look at it?

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Children's room

What works. Calmer green shades help to slow down, especially in connection with wood and plants. A green rug, cushion or storage box is soft and movable.

What to watch for. In a child's room the child's taste also decides. A muted background and a few livelier details are easier to change than a whole bright room.

Study

What works. A soft sage or a green picture give the eyes **a calmer background** between tasks. Green alone does not raise performance, but combined with natural materials it helps calm.

What to watch for. If you edit photographs, judge shades or do make-up, large rich green areas and green light can distort the perception of other colours.

A simple tip. Matt wood or paper leave green in the background. A glossy green surface in the main view can reflect into the eyes.

Bathroom and hall

What works. In a bathroom a blue-green can be pleasant on tiles. In a hall a smaller picture or a plant in a lighter spot.

What to watch for. A green bulb by the mirror distorts the skin, so keep neutral light by the mirror. In a narrow dark hall a large forest-coloured area can visually close the space.

A simple tip. Does the entrance welcome you, or does the first look shout at you? And how does it feel to look at yourself in the mirror?

Where to put a plant or a green picture

You can use **a potted houseplant**, a picture of a forest or your own green painting. In feng shui they are meant to recall growth and renewal. In an ordinary flat look for a place where you will gladly see them and where they will make sense to you. Place a living plant according to how much light it needs. If the conditions for it are not there, choose a picture.

If I asked you now

"*Why do I want green at home?* ***What is it meant to bring me, calm, growth or freshness?***"

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